offering greater incentives for closer cooperation. A polity like India should display the wisdom of treating its prosperity as a lifting tide for the entire region. That means assigning a higher degree of attention and greater resources, a policy captured by Neighbourhood First.

Neighbours pose challenges everywhere and India cannot escape having its fair share. To keep such relationships steady, India should invest in greater structural inter-linkages. These could help mitigate situations that would inevitably arise from time to time. Having recognized that, it is also important that where there are real problems, we do not duck them. Generosity and firmness must go hand in hand. In the last few years, India has done well where it has defined its interests with clarity and trusted its own instincts. It has also been the magnet around which global opinion has crystallized in respect of the region. That it has responded positively to those neighbours who are prepared to engage India more intensively is also a welcome development.

At a time when most are pursuing interests narrowly, it is to India's benefit that it takes a more expansive view of the world. By stepping forward in difficult situations, it can not only underline its greater capabilities and confidence but also build its unique brand as a generous power. This imagery fits in well with the embrace of the world that is inherent in Indian thinking and reinforces its positioning as a power that can bridge divides.

The unfolding of this approach has been in the making over the last few years. It has been expressed especially through initiatives responding to natural calamities. These activities have helped to prepare the nation to be the first responder to crisis situations in the larger region. India has surely but steadily assisted in underwriting the global commons when that has come under stress. Its physical presence is supported by declared respect for international law and norms, a position which it has made credible by setting an example in dispute resolution. Nationalism, contributing to global good, is powerful for brand building.

Given history, it is natural that the rise of nationalism across regions should impact the Westernization of the world. Our world functions largely in the framework of Western concepts and norms. At least in Asia, we can talk of an economic rise with attendant cultural confidence. Other continents are